

BEWARE OF MOBILES

The debate on the potential health hazards of cell phones is simmering once again. Even though the data are mixed and experts differ, the Government has now sounded the alarm. How harmful is your mobile?

■ By Damayanti Datta

For a nation that loves to talk, cell phones have become a lifeline. Metro Indians talk seven hours and text 56 messages a week on average, while more than 50 per cent tune in to mobile music even at work. But the figures, thrown up by a study last year by market research company IDC India, don't quite capture how much the gadget has become a part of our lives. From one in 10 urban homes owning a landline a decade back, India is now the world's fastest-growing mobile market, selling eight million cell phones a month. With 250 million Indians owning a handset, you're a problem for others if you don't have one. But the power of words may just turn out to be too much of a good thing. The Union Health Ministry has raised the critical question: how safe are mobile phones?

"The question is not new," says Dr Suresh Advani, director of medical oncology at Mumbai's Jaslok Hospital.

"Researchers all over the world have been probing it for a decade, with little resolution," he adds. But unlike in the West, India has been largely indifferent to the potential health hazards (59 per cent city-slickers are "least bothered", says the IDC India survey). The alarm started beeping when the technical wing of the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) found levels of radiation at certain base stations in Delhi far in excess of global norms. The DoT sat up, took note that India does not implement international mobile-safety tenets and rolled out a draft guideline: "The studies of possible hazards to human health from exposure to electromagnetic fields suggest that there is need to control the unwanted exposure as per the World Health Organisation guidelines". And the health ministry tooted the warning that mobile radiation may be harmful, asked service-providers and makers to avoid promotional ads featuring children and pregnant women and commissioned India's first large-scale study

"Most studies have been on people using mobiles for three to five years. **TUMOURS** can take twice as long to develop."

CAN YOUR MOBILE HARM YOU?

Long and heavy use can, say scientists...

CANCER



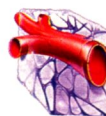
Radiation not strong enough to break chemical bonds in the body. But heavy use may enhance the risk of brain cancer.

TUMOURS



Scientists link up long-term use to brain tumours. The risk of ear tumours is believed to go up four-folds.

DEGENERATION



Radiation may break the protective blood brain barrier as seen in diseases like MS, Alzheimer's or Parkinson's.

DEAFNESS



Long-term use, especially on one ear, may damage tissues in the inner-ear and lead to deafness.